



## JAMAICA CARIBBEAN



## Fiery Jerk Chicken in Jamaica

Jamaica is renowned for its vivid colors, from the alabaster beaches and indigo-hued mountain peaks to rain forests filled with tropical blooms. Old traditions are upheld with pride in the fishing villages and colonial-era towns, from bygone culinary secrets to riotous folkloric festivals and rhythmic dance. But reggae and food – Bob Marley and jerk chicken – remain Jamaica's lifeblood.



From swanky coastal resorts and handsome colonial towns to neon-lit nightlife, Jamaica offers a variety of historic and cultural attractions.

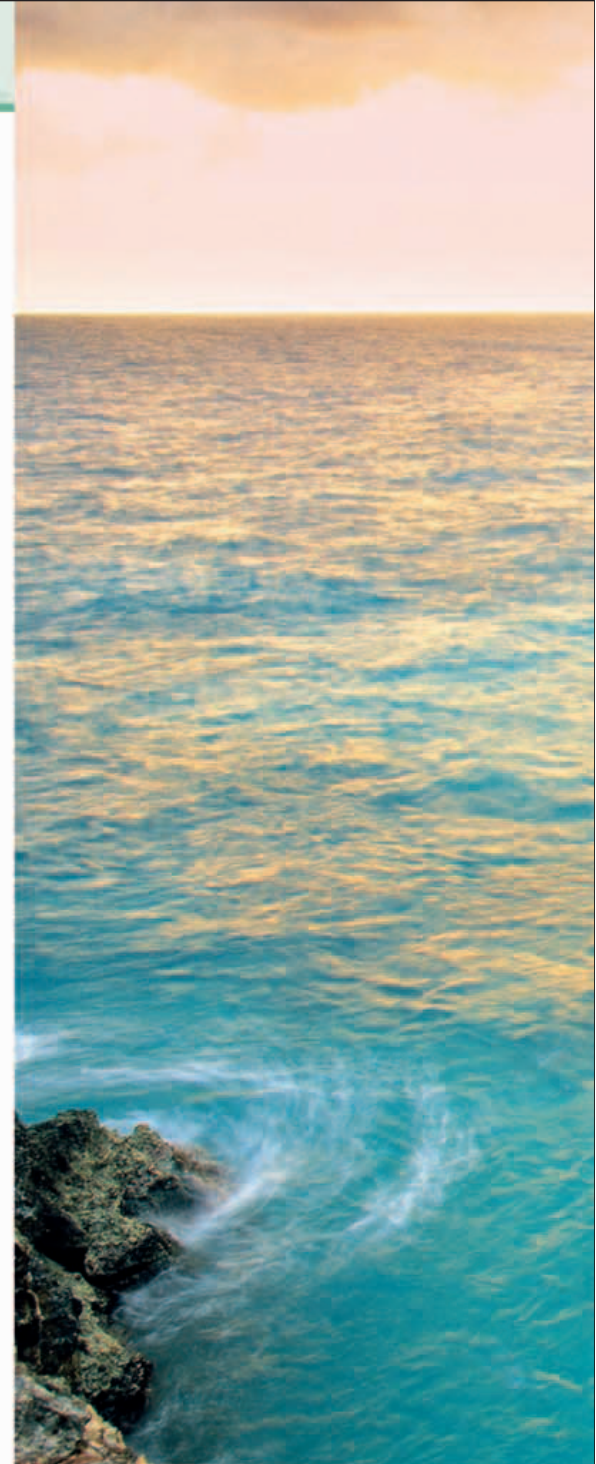
Lively Negril and Montego Bay,

Jamaica's two main tourist areas, boast a mix of plush bars and rustic reggae-and-rum shacks together with long stretches of soft sands, popular restaurants, and world-class golf. Montego Bay, known colloquially as Mo' Bay, upholds its reputation as a party town with great gusto with after-dark haunts that run from funky lounge bars and pumping discos to steel-pan gigs on the beach. Sleepy villages hug the 620 miles (1,000 km) of coastline, offering the quieter natural attractions of scenic Treasure Beach, Port Antonio, and Oracabessa. Fertile farmlands and meadows form a colorful patchwork between mountainous ridges and forested ravines in a setting of palm-flanked azure seas, where fishing boats drag their nets ashore and sell their haul at tables on the sand.

In historic central Kingston, the hypnotic, pulsating rhythm of languid reggae is a laid-back beat in Jamaica's otherwise fast-paced metropolis. Snack

vendors vie for attention over tooting horns, blaring car stereos, and the cries of street hawkers; housewives swap gossip over plates of ackee and saltfish as the aromas of slow-cooked seafood stews, seasoned chicken, and fire-roasted meats hang in the air. No local snack is more commonly sought out than the full-flavored "jerk," a uniquely Jamaican way of preserving and cooking meats and poultry.

Believed to have derived from the ancient hot-stone cooking practices of the indigenous Arawak people, jerk fuses smoky Jamaican pimento with the fiery-hot, blood-red chili peppers originally brought here from South American shores by 16th-century mariners. Salt is added as part of the marinade, and then the meat is roasted much as it was in times gone by, when escaped slaves, known as maroons, spent years living in the Blue Mountains battling attempts at recapture by the British troops. Today, the deep, intense and complex jerk flavor is synonymous with Jamaican kitchens and a true test of culinary prowess. Every home has its own "secret" recipe, handed down through generations. Pride runs high among jerk cooks in Jamaica – each of whom considers "their" jerk the best.



**Above** Rick's Café sits beside a favorite jumping-off point, and its position on the West End Cliffs of Negril makes it a great place to enjoy sunsets with a cold beer

### Food Markets

Few experiences in Jamaica excite the senses quite like a stroll around the island's many colorful food markets. Flower stands stacked with a rainbow of scented blooms sit among food stands selling Blue Mountain coffee, freshly cut coconut, and sugary cakes still warm to the touch. Housewives haggle over breadfruit, pimentos, codfish, plantain, avocados, and callaloo, near red-hot grills that sizzle with skewers of seasoned pork, beef, and chicken wedged between juicy green peppers. Choose from rice and peas, jerk chicken, beef patties, or freshly cooked johnny cakes (fried dough biscuits) or banana fritters in Kingston's chaotic Coronation Market, Linstead Market in charming St. Catherine, Brownstown Market in St. Anne, or the Savanna-la-mar Market in Westmoreland.

### Three Days in Jamaica

Jamaica's extraordinary natural beauty runs through its mountain, beach, and rain forest regions. Its villages and colonial settlements have enthralling histories, and central Kingston has an irrepressibly vibrant nightlife.

**DAY ONE** Stroll around the historic streets of Kingston's **Spanish Town** in the relative cool of the morning to marvel at the magnificent homes, plaza, and monuments. After lunch, visit the city's harbor museum, **Port Royal**, a memorial to the ancient capital city that was submerged following an earthquake in 1692. Then head to Hope Road to the **Bob Marley Museum** to revel in his writings.

**DAY TWO** Pack a picnic to hike through the bird-filled vegetation and coffee plantations around the **Blue Mountains**, perpetually cloaked in blue-tinged mists.

**DAY THREE** Spend a morning chilling out on ultra-hip **Doctor's Cave Beach** in **Montego Bay** to enjoy beautiful white sands and sparkling spring-fed waters. After lunch, explore a rainbow of underwater gardens in Mo' Bay's outlying shallow spurs from a glass-bottomed tour boat, a snorkel boat, or in a group dive; an old anchor from a Spanish galleon begs discovery on the marine park's western side.

### Essentials

#### GETTING THERE

**Montego Bay International Airport** is 2 miles (3 km) north of Kingston and there are **shuttle buses** into town.

#### WHERE TO STAY

**Klem's Homestay** (inexpensive) is a charming place to experience typical Jamaican hospitality. [www.klemshomestay.hostel.com](http://www.klemshomestay.hostel.com)

**Rockhouse Hotel** (moderate) is an affordable boutique hotel set on secluded cliffs in Negril with an infinity pool. [www.rockhousehotel.com](http://www.rockhousehotel.com)

**Ritz Carlton Rose Hall** (expensive) offers beach-fronted luxury with a golf course, spa, and five restaurants. [www.ritzcarlton.com](http://www.ritzcarlton.com)

#### TOURIST INFORMATION

[www.visitjamaica.com](http://www.visitjamaica.com)